



CHAPTER 2.1

This part of the chapter is perhaps one of the most difficult for me to write. Not because I do not know what happened. But because I do.

Andrea Schertzer was one of my lecturers at Regent's University. I recall as clear as yesterday the moment I heard that extraordinary New York -ish accented. I wanted to know that woman. She spoke with conviction. The subject that she was guardians with was the modality of being an integrative psychotherapist. Andrea taught integrative psychotherapy, but one of the first lessons she offered had very little to do with theory. "I want you to consider what is *your* integration."

Over time, she became my supervisor and eventually my master supervisor. More than that, she became one of the most influential people I have ever encountered. She challenged the way I thought.

The way I worked. The way I understood myself. Looking back now, I hardly recognise the person I was before I met her. Andrea had an extraordinary ability to see beyond the stories people told about themselves. She could see the fear beneath the confidence, the uncertainty beneath the certainty and the potential hidden beneath years of self-doubt.

She saw all of me. The strengths. The insecurities. The ambition. The self-sabotage. The desire to give up. The determination to fight. And perhaps most importantly, she saw possibilities in me that I could not yet see for myself. For that, I will always be grateful. Not only was Andrea one of the greatest blessings of my professional life, she has also become one of my greatest regrets. The two truths sit alongside each other. Neither cancels out the other. And perhaps that is why writing about her remains so difficult but also giving her the space and narrative that her influence on me deserves.



At the time, I thought she was talking about modalities.
Years later, I realised she was talking about something much deeper.
Integration is not a modality.
It is a way of being.
It is the ongoing process of bringing together all the fragmented parts of ourselves and allowing them to exist in relationship with one another.
The frightened parts.
The confident parts.
The wounded parts.
The hopeful parts.
The contradictions.
The complexities.
The truths we would rather avoid.
Andrea understood that better than anyone I had ever met.
Over time, she became my supervisor and eventually my Master's supervisor.
More than that, she became one of the most influential people I have ever encountered.
She challenged the way I thought.
The way I worked.
The way I understood myself.
Looking back now, I hardly recognise the person I was before I met her.

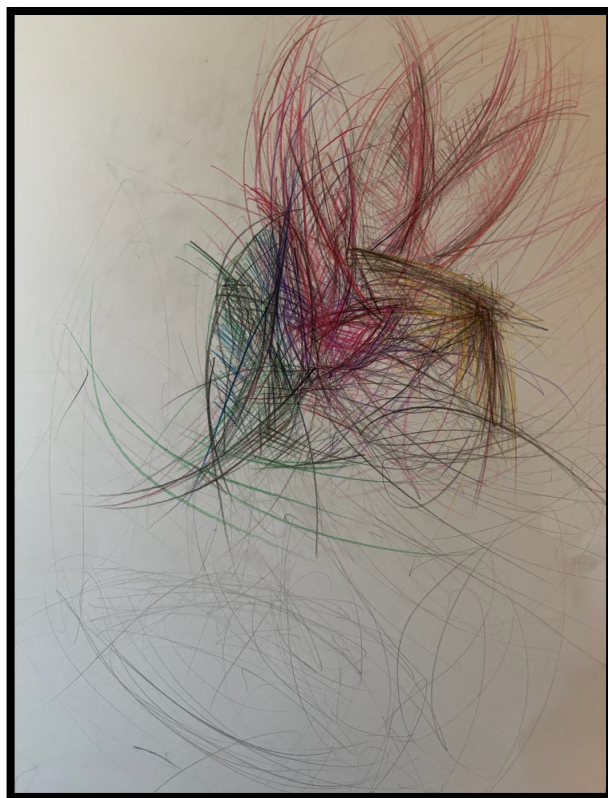
"I want you to consider what is your integration. "At the time, I thought she was talking about modalities. Jungian. Gestalt. Psychodynamic. Person-centred. Existential. CBT. Theoretical approaches that could somehow be combined into a coherent therapeutic style. Then I sat through my first year at Regent's.

By the end of it, my head was doing its best impression of an exploding emoji. The more I learned, the less certain I became. What exactly was I integrating? What was I supposed to become? Then slowly, almost without noticing, I began to understand what Andrea was asking. Integration was not a modality? It was not a technique. It was not a clever way of combining different therapeutic approaches. Integration is a way of being. It is the ongoing process of bringing together all the different parts of ourselves. The parts we celebrate. The parts we hide. The parts we are proud of. The parts we would rather pretend never existed.

The frightened child. The recovering addict. The anorexic. The gay man. The student. The therapist. The survivor. The dreamer. The fighter. Not choosing between them. Not ranking them. Not denying them. But allowing them all a seat at the same table. That was Andrea's challenge.
And it would take me years to understand just how profound it really was. _____

Now, by no means was I going to graduate cum laude on that paper, but I was more than happy with a solid 2:1.
What it gave me was something far more valuable.
A foundation. Proof that grit could sometimes achieve what confidence could not.
I've never quite known where the line sits between determination and sheer bloody-minded obstinacy, but in this case I suspect it took a healthy dose of both.
And an army. Andrea. Chris. Friends. Colleagues.
People who continued believing in me long after I had temporarily stopped believing in myself.
More importantly, it ignited a thirst for academia and research.
IPA, experiential phenomenology, the way human beings construct meaning from their experiences; all of it fascinated me. I realised that being a therapist wasn't simply about accumulating clinical hours.
It was about remaining curious. Mental health isn't static.
People aren't static.
So neither can therapists be.
If we expect our clients to grow and change, we have to be willing to do the same.
But this is where things start getting messy.
COVID arrived.
Lockdown happened.

And somehow we were all expected to carry on. Mental health, however, didn't stop because Boris Johnson told it to stay at home and socially distance. Anxiety carried on. Depression carried on. Trauma carried on. People still needed help. Now not every service chose to step into frontline work, but me being me, there was absolutely no chance I was sitting at home whilst NHS colleagues worked themselves into the ground.
So, boots and all, I joined a specialist NHS mental health response team.
And if I'm being completely honest, I loved it.
The urgency.
The purpose.
The feeling that everyone was pulling in the same direction
There was something almost wartime about it. At the same time, I was still seeing private clients, still working for Mind, and still meeting Andrea weekly for supervision.



This story would be incomplete without mentioning the extraordinary Sid.
Her words affected me so deeply that I had three arrows tattooed onto my forearm.
At the base of one of them are her initials, **CV**, a permanent reminder of a woman who taught me far more than I ever taught her.
Around that time, I had been asked to organise Cancer Survivors' Day at Guy's and St Thomas'.
We transformed the event into a celebration. Survivors were treated to makeovers before walking a runway in front of family, friends and staff.
Sid insisted on being there.
Technically, she wasn't a survivor.
She was living with Stage IV cancer.
But Sid had no intention of letting a diagnosis decide whether she belonged.
She was an exceptionally talented make-up artist.
At six o'clock that morning, she arrived with everyone else and spent hours transforming the faces of fourteen cancer survivors before they walked onto that runway.
At the end of the day she smiled at me and simply said,
"I survived today."
Six weeks later, she died.
Even now, I think about that day.
Not because it was the end of her story.
But because it perfectly captured how she chose to live it.
She taught me that making a difference has nothing to do with how much time we have.
It has everything to do with what we choose to do with the time we are given.
That lesson has stayed with me ever since.



To my Grandad
Chris Hall the
fighting
cancer

Miss you Dad
for more
survivors in
the future
of cancer
research



Hazel we are so proud
of you
A Celebration of Hope
xxxxx

Dad,
Love you
always
xxxxx

For Mother
Love
xxxxx

